



Above The streets of Thessaloniki are lined with high-quality restaurants and tempting *ouzeri*

Left Thessaloniki, also known as Salonika, sits around a spacious harbor built by the Romans



Above Dolmades are cigar-shaped, stuffed vine leaves bursting with flavor; a subtle scent of lemon tantalizes the taste buds

The Modiano Market

The glass-domed Modiano, built in 1922, is Thessaloniki's best and biggest food market. It's a celebration of the city's culinary diversity: stands are heaped with glistening olives, sticky pastries, delicate rosebuds, pickled peppers, fragrant mounds of saffron, and briny buckets of vine leaves. There are several places to sample meze inside the market, which echoes day and night with the banter of bargain-hunters and *bon viveurs*. Gypsy minstrels weave among tightly packed tables, where shoppers dig in to tiny plates of grilled sardines or smoky eggplant purée. The beauty of these shared feasts is their spontaneity – and the fact that they can go on indefinitely.

The Best Places to Eat Dolmades

Aristotelous moderate

This classic *ouzeri* is a throwback to another era. Situated in a plant-filled arcade decorated with checkerboard tiles and retro posters of Greece, it offers calm respite from the hustle of Aristotelous Square. Writers and artists, lawyers and lovers squeeze around the marble-topped tables while genteel waiters ply them with a parade of little dishes. You must, of course, try the dolmades. But it's also a good place to dip into the vast repertoire of meze dishes – red peppers stuffed with spicy feta, shrimp sautéed with garlic and tomato, squid oozing cheese sauce, and lightly battered zucchini. With live Greek music most evenings, the experience is as much about the atmosphere as the food. Tourists have discovered its charms, so you often have to wait for a table and prices are a little steep. Yet the appeal of this former Turkish coffeehouse, which miraculously survived the great fire that ravaged Thessaloniki in 1917, is as enduring as ever.

Aristotelous 8, Thessaloniki; open 10 AM–2 AM Mon–Sat, 11 AM–6 PM Sun; +30 2310 233 195

Also in Thessaloniki

Aglaia's Kitchen (+30 2310 280 044; inexpensive) is a tiny restaurant with a menu straight out of Asia Minor, situated in the heart of the flower market. Dishes of the day depend on what Aglaia finds in nearby Modiano market, but if you're lucky the day's menu will include her legendary *sarmadakia*, smothered in *avgolemono*. The sophisticated bistro **B (+30 2310 280 044; moderate)** is also known as **Vyzantino**, after its location in the Byzantine Museum. It serves tasty dolmades with minted yogurt, and you can enjoy a tour of the museum's frescoes, mosaics, and icons as a marvelous *digestif*.

Also in Greece

The far-flung isle of Kasos in the Dodecanese is renowned for its tiny dolmades (or *dourmaes*, as they are called in the local dialect). The best place to try them is **Emborios (www.emborios.com; inexpensive)**, a lively, family-run taverna, which serves addictive meze accompanied by fantastically fresh fish and improvised singalongs to a lyre and lute.

Around the World

Melbourne, Australia, has the largest Greek community outside Greece, so it's not surprising that it has several excellent Greek restaurants.

Philhellene (www.philhellene.com.au; moderate) is like eating at home with the garrulous Rerakis family, whose beef and cumin dolmades are wrapped in silverbeet leaves grown in their own garden. Don't miss their wonderful stuffed zucchini flowers, only featured when in season.